MACHINE TRANSCRIPT · CORAGGIO CONSULTING

Virginia Board of Education, Work Session, Wednesday, April 21, 2021

Date	Wednesday, April 21, 2021
Place	Virginia Board of Education (Virginia Department of Education), Richmond, Virginia
Length	1h 17m (video)

- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rKIx9lmLEV0
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

> Machine transcript (speech-to-text) produced by Coraggio Consulting. Not an official county record. Names and numbers may be misspelled; check the video at the timestamp before quoting.

Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-24. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:00:00] the in the works congratulations on all that good work oh thanks actually the most exciting thing we're doing right now is uh beginning a hydroponic garden up in stanton we're going to try to do something a little bit different inside one of the historic buildings we are uh building out the hydroponic facility that will be terrific to watch yeah we'll see i mean it's an experiment you know something we believe in trying so you know it's not about the money at this point it's just about doing something that we think will be interesting for the future well you're you've got

[00:00:37] virginia center comments too right i'm a very small piece of that regency is a much more significant piece of me right yeah that that pool that regency is getting a lot of buzz uh it's very cool i was up there i guess last wednesday i mean it's it's coming right along yeah yeah i'm i don't live that far from regency so i've seen a lot of a lot of the change property values going up all of that so it's exciting. Yeah I think you know what's going on at Regency is a pretty good example of

[00:01:15] how change can occur you know not rapidly necessarily but you know with a pretty consistently positive direction you know repurposing a structure like that is pretty cool. And I've been fascinated watching kind of the demolition of Virginia Center Commons being from Hanover I remember

it being built and how it was the cool place to go and now you know so much of it being gone it's been it's been interesting to watch that evolution over the years yep it'll be the cool place again

[00:01:55] good morning everybody good morning good morning morning good morning my keisha coffee good morning good morning and i'm sorry i will not be with you guys tomorrow but um you'll be missed i'll be

[00:02:31] available afterwards good morning everybody just to let you know we are live on uh youtube and we will get started here in just a couple of minutes once we have everybody with us good morning miss holton good morning mr president and i'll hope everybody's enjoying this beautiful day we're still on zoom

[00:03:09] hopefully we all have a window nearby anyway critical i'm actually looking at the azaleas now all right i'm going to pull up just the home home page so folks that are joining us on youtube know what meeting this is and then we'll i'll pull it down dan as soon as we are ready to get started

[00:03:39] that's fine good morning everyone morning melissa hey i didn't see is jenna with us yet not quite yet don't see her on dr bassic is here hello welcome morning and uh mr gecker i just want to let you know jenna was leading a webinar that wraps a tent so she should be here right at time

[00:04:15] okay well and dr wilford good morning thank you for being with us morning thank you good morning morning tammy yep always does seem like an episode of the waltons every time i do this good morning john boy exactly it's much better than i guess the brady bunch

[00:04:52] morning everyone morning pam morning pam emily i just uh texted jenna and uh she says she only

[00:05:38] got tomorrow's panel invite so if you can yes it's been sent it's been sent to her um accidentally sent it to a doe email which is not her exchange so i have resent it to her there she is all right

[00:06:10] i'm gonna go ahead and pull this down so we can make sure everybody's here all the board is here as i count them up emily does that square with what you think i think all nine are here yes we

[00:06:44] are everybody is here sorry i was counting it's easier when we're in person and we can just see if there's an empty chair this actually requires some work and skill like the world where's waldo view of the world all right i guess uh emily we're live and ready yes we are live on youtube and ready to go. Perfect. And we're going to call the meeting to order. I'd like to thank everybody for being here. This is the Wednesday work session of the Board of Education. As many of you know,

[00:07:18] we have a busy week. We had a meeting yesterday. We have this this morning, followed by our retreat also on Zoom this afternoon and the regular business meeting of the Board tomorrow. You know, I think it's well known by now that the Board of Ed has been tasked with responsibility now for you know birth decay uh this is i guess not the beginning of but you know along today's session we'll deal with uh early childhood education uh we are pleased to have a distinguished panel with us

[00:07:54] uh dr bassick uh dr wilford and of course the chief school readiness officer for the commonwealth of virginia jenna conway so jenna i'm going to turn this over to you if that's okay and we can get started. Absolutely. Thanks. Good morning, everyone, and it's great to see everyone.

[00:08:16] In preparing today's session, I think as Mr. Gecker noted, we recognize you all are in the midst of a really significant evolution from really thinking about a pre-K to 12 system to a birth to 12 system. You

are fortunate to have an extraordinary member who has extensive zero to three and birth to five experience as well as elementary school leaders who have some experience in managing the pre-k and early childhood special education but i think as i've talked with you all over the course of the last year we realized there's an opportunity in bits and pieces and

[00:08:55] work sessions to bring outside experts in to help just to share more information about what's happening more broadly in the early childhood world insights from research we are fortunate enough to have incredible institutes of higher education and research institutes across our state and so one of the things that i've talked with dr lane and emily and others about is really being thoughtful as we take on some of these big topics like how do we license for the health and safety of child care how should we think about quality measurement and improvement that we bring bring this information to you and that you can hear I know you love hearing from me

[00:09:35] but that you can hear from experts in the field who can share the most up-to-date research so with our partners today from the University of Virginia School of Education really excited to share some information today about research and what's happening both nationally and in the commonwealth and this is a precursor to what I'll be bringing to you tomorrow for first review as we think about Virginia's first statewide measurement and improvement system. So our focus today is not going to be on health and safety, it's not going to be on how we fund child care,

[00:10:11] not going to be on kind of on those details. Today we're really going to focus on what's happening in our classrooms and again I want you to start off today even thinking broadly like put classrooms in quotes because I want you to be thinking about the birth to five system as Mr. Gecker noted and that includes our small family day homes for which incredible women have created classrooms right in their homes that serve a small number of children across age groups our child care centers whether located in a community center in a church or in a standalone building right those are kind of infant toddler preschool classrooms our head start programs whether in

[00:10:49] schools or in community buildings have three and four year old classrooms maybe classrooms that are mixed infant and toddler if they offer early head start and then in our schools often in elementary schools um sometimes at the elementary school so you have an early childhood special education classroom and a vpi classroom that's part of a k-5 or k-3 or k-8 or you might also have standalone preschool programs where all that you have on that school campus is is is preschool classroom so with that in mind emily she'll take us to the next slide i'll give you a sense of what we're

[00:11:21] we're going to cover today. So what we wanted to do today, and we're not going to talk, say for tomorrow, kind of what we do about it, but what we're going to do today is just look at the current research related to thinking about measuring and supporting quality. So again, as a reminder for you, as Mr. Gecker noted, you are now taking responsibility for the oversight of this system.

[00:11:47] That's what was spelled out in the law last year. The law also said that the board is in charge of establishing a uniform measurement and improvement system, right? So it's more than just sort of unifying. It explicitly says that you're in charge of that. We're going to work with you over the course of the next few years to roll that out thoughtfully and carefully across the state.

[00:12:08] But what we wanted to do this morning is to orient you on what's happening nationally as it relates to measuring and supporting quality improvement, right? And those things go hand in hand. What is measured is often what people pay attention to, what they say matters. And as you know, we'll hear

today and tomorrow, like the most important part of this is about what you do with those measurements, right? How you support improvement. You'll notice some analogs from your work around accreditation, right? And how you really shifted from just focusing on measuring where kids are at and where their disparities to really thinking about what do we do to support school quality? What do

[00:12:44] do to support continuous improvement? How is that the kind of the key priority, for example, for our accreditation system? So we'll talk a little bit about core elements of quality learning, early learning in birth to five settings. Talking about kind of interactions and curriculum is two really important elements there. Then thinking about what we've learned nationally around measuring and improving quality in early childhood. How we think about improvement at scale, right, going beyond kind of just an individual site or community effort. How we think about educators And again, I know we've talked a lot about this. We define educators very broadly here. If you are the person in charge of supporting a child's learning and development, we call you an educator.

[00:13:23] So this is a slightly broader definition than just those individuals that hold Virginia teaching licenses. This is our family day home educators, our child care educators, as well as our school based educators. And then I think something that we've heard is really important as I've listened in on the accreditation conversations, how do we support growth over time? And again, wanted today to talk about this broadly before I come to you tomorrow and present our kind of first review for first review our proposal for how to begin this work in Virginia next slide please so this just as a kind of reminder of where we are this shows you what we know about Virginia

[00:14:02] learners Virginia is one of the few states and we're glad to have Dr. Williford and Dr. Whitaker today here and Dr. McGinty who have you know helped us get to a place where we have apples to apples information around all of our entering kindergartners anywhere between 90 95 and thousand children students in virginia on any given year and what we see is when we look at the vkrp which looks at literacy math self-regulation and social skills we know that our system does not provide every child equitable opportunity to be successful and we look at things like income right as a

[00:14:39] a predictor right now it unfortunately predicts if you were from a lower income household you are more likely to not have that opportunity to come to school ready and we know these are the things that are important not just for purposes of a test right but those those intangible social skills and ability to manage your regulations these are things that help you not only be successful in the kindergarten classroom but um you know throughout your educational and even your career and college experience next slide please and before i i turn it over to our experts just want to kind of start to talk about the what we think the why is behind this right and we've really worked to be very

[00:15:18] thoughtful about our language i've learned a lot from working so closely with dr lane and leah and others that we don't want to kind of put any of this on the shoulders of kids right particularly some of our kids who are furthest from opportunity we really think this is about the adult system right and that we know that there are two real key challenges that we'll work closely with you over the course of the next few years to address first of all is that kids need access right and we're working kind of to get more resources so that we can serve more kids we know that early childhood can work we know that early childhood can work in our public settings and we have an incredible evidence basis around vpi vpi plus we know that early childhood could work in our private settings

[00:15:57] we have kind of demonstrated successes you know in bcf mixed delivery and in head start right we know it can make a difference, but not all kids have access. Right now, we have a bit of a pay-to-play system. You've heard me say this before, right? Infant and toddler care costs more than tuition at most places. I don't remember about George Mason in particular, but I do know for many places, like, it is literally more expensive than college, right? And there's no FAFSA, there's no PEL, there's a few programs, but it remains out of reach for many families. And as you'll hear from our national experts today, we know even if you get a slot that there's a ton of variability

[00:16:32] around quality and that oftentimes that's not because of the everybody comes to this work with the best of intentions but programs have different access to resources and support and you know we think about kind of our infant and toddler care which is most expensive and yet still our teachers get paid the least and have some of the greatest challenges in terms of being able to achieve quality and so you'll really hear us try to make sure that we center this work recognizing the incredible efforts of families to support their children recognizing the incredible efforts of educators but knowing that we have to make some systemic changes and investments to really

[00:17:09] make sure that more kids have access and that more programs have that opportunity to meet these kind of quality expectations with that i'm going to turn it over to my uva colleagues ask them to introduce themselves and then we can go from here um so uh hi i'm amanda Wilford. I am the Associate Director for Early Childhood Education at the Center for Advanced Study of Teaching and Learning at the School of Education. I'll turn it over to Daphna to

[00:17:45] introduce yourself. Good morning. I am Daphna Bissach. I'm an Associate Professor also at the University of Virginia, and I am the Associate Director of Ed Policy Works, our Education Policy Center at UVA. And Jessica? Good morning, everyone. My name is Jessica Whitaker, and I'm an Associate

[00:18:07] professor at CASEL with Amanda. And Anita. Good morning, everyone. I'm Anita McIntyre. I'm a research associate professor at UVA, associated with CASEL. I'm also the director of PALS. Great. And I'm going to talk through a set of slides here on understanding core elements of quality and early learning in both the five settings. And we're kind of going to swap back and forth across my colleagues today. And so Daphna and I will do some presenting, but Jessica and Anita, please

[00:18:41] jump in as we're walking through the slides as well as needed. So next slide please. So I think when we're talking about statewide change, it requires a focus on factors that are consistently linked to child development. And we know that high quality early learning experiences set the stage for school success and can narrow early opportunity gaps. We know that that has to be high quality and that what that means for all children is different so it has to be sensitive

[00:19:17] and responsive it needs to be culturally sensitive to children's needs but it must be high quality if we wanted to narrow opportunity gaps and we know that the adults who care for interact with and teach young children are the key drivers of high quality and early learning opportunities so they are the people these are educators and when i say teachers i am also talking very broadly birth to five settings any educator or adult who is interacting with a child whether it be in a preschool classroom child care or family day home but they drive those interactions from day to day

[00:19:53] we also know that curriculum can provide structure and materials that support those intentional interactions between children and adults next slide please um adult child interactions are fundamental to children's early learning and development and here we'll define interactions as the

ongoing back-and-forth exchanges between a child and significant others parents siblings peers and teachers in their environment and they are essential to supporting children's learning and development so responsive interactions with teachers help infants toddlers preschool age

[00:20:32] children all the way up really through higher ed they do support they provide especially in early childhood a secure base a reliable source of comfort and safety very similar to caregiver interactions and at home and in which to explore their environments and kind of set the stage for learning and the scaffolded interactions with teachers help children master increasingly difficult tasks and extend their learning and development and this is where the high quality part comes into that ability of teachers to kind of meet children where exactly where they are

[00:21:09] and know how to kind of help scaffold them to complete the next task that will support their learning. Next slide please. We find the evidence of the research indicates that high quality adult child interactions are linked with children's learning and development across all childhood settings and this is really important because I think the core of these interactions and even whether you were looking at caregiver child interactions or teacher child interactions again

[00:21:44] broadly defined we have a robust evidence base that shows that children in classrooms where we measure high quality interactions as high and sensitive and responsive and scaffolded do benefit children academically, socially, behaviorally, and we see this across a variety of settings.

[00:22:04] And I think that that is really important if we think about the settings in which these studies have been done and where we see these consistent links between quality adult child interactions and learning and development. Next slide. And now I'm going to shift over to curriculum. And Curriculum, when we think about curriculum in early childhood education, you know, we're thinking about the plans for learning experiences through which children acquire skills, knowledge, abilities

[00:22:38] and understanding. A good early childhood curriculum, it helps define and sequence learning goals. It provides structure and routines. If the activities are developmentally appropriate and culturally sensitive it supports children engagement throughout the day um some curriculums provide more scripting to help children to help teachers scaffold children's learning and what i mean by that is like some curriculum actually provide scaffolds to teachers to help explain

[00:23:13] concepts that then support children's learning i think a good example of this can be you can think about this in terms of math where some of early childhood teachers don't have prior training and skills to like understand math concepts so providing a little bit of scripting can actually help them feel more comfortable and understand um how that activity is actually supporting learning and then um a curriculum can also promote consistency across classrooms i will say a good curriculum can also provide really support just to our early childhood programs where they

[00:23:50] where we're facing this is many early childhood programs we face issues of turnover because it helps provide consistency for children so a teacher might need to move into a new classroom or a teacher may leave throughout the year we know this is a major problem in early childhood classrooms but a curriculum that is used within a program provides a consistency that a child needs so they understand the structure still from day to day and that can remain the same and even understand the scope and sequence about what's happening in terms of learning in the classroom.

[00:24:22] Next slide. Importantly, supporting educators to use curriculum yields greater impact for kids, and this is critically important. I think a curriculum that is not used is not of use, and we know that curriculum use paired with ongoing support for teachers to use that curriculum yields the strongest impacts for school readiness and we have research from implementation science that shows this again and again across different curriculum and then we also show and we also have

[00:24:58] evidence that even when a curriculum is in place the variability of the use of that curriculum varies widely so again it's the it's the evidence that support for curriculum use or support for an intervention use or a strategy is critically important and this has to happen at the program and the educator level they need professional development support to implement curriculum with high fidelity i will just say i was in virginia this was a few years ago working in a professional development workshop and i was kind of walking around some tables and i was

[00:25:37] talking to some teachers and i don't remember what program they were in but they were talking about this curriculum that um that they were not using it was the pat it was a path social emotional curriculum now the path social emotional curriculum is one of the most um research uh based curriculum and social emotional that are out there there's strong evidence for it to be effective but these teachers they knew nothing about this curriculum a box showed up outside of their classroom door over the summer and most of those teachers honestly told me they were like i didn't even

[00:26:12] open the box i have no idea what this curriculum is and it went into a shelf in my classroom and so and that was that was the right move these the teachers were not supported at all to to understand what that curriculum is why it was a value or what it was and so you can have the best curriculum materials and they never be used so i do want to emphasize the importance on the implementation um and and the research that we show that we can support that implementation and and that it will yield greater impact. Next slide. Okay. Now I am going to turn it over to Daphna to

[00:26:47] talk about measuring and improving quality in early childhood. Awesome. Thank you, Amanda. So I wanted to pivot a little bit from what Amanda was talking to you about, which is kind of what does the science say about how do we support young children and how do we help them learn and how do we do that in classroom settings? And she really emphasized the kind of core importance of teacher-child interactions as well as curriculum as a way to help with those interactions. And what I'm studying and what I want to talk about today is, you know, how do we take what psychologists and the research shows about classrooms and what is a high quality classroom

[00:27:24] and how do we start thinking about improving whole systems at scale? So not kind of how can we make one good classroom and describe what works in there, but how do we move a whole system along through policies and systems to create that change. So on the next line, oftentimes when cities or states are thinking about this kind of quality improvement, they think about it in a lot of different ways. And so the kind of interaction quality and curricula, which Amanda talked about,

[00:27:59] is among the things that people talk about, but there's a whole long list of other types of measures of quality. So you might think, and this is in lots of ways similar to how we think about K-12, you might think about the teacher's education levels or professional development or the training teachers receive. You might think about classroom environments, like what do the spaces look like, what kind of materials are available, who are the leaders, do we need certain characteristics for the directors of child

care centers or the principals of schools, what are we doing on family engagement? How do we and do we assess all the children? Do we know where they are? Are we

[00:28:37] tracking that at a basic level? Are we thinking about health and safety and ensuring that these places are just safe for children to go? And in child care, a lot of times we're thinking about the ratios, the group sizes, and as well as kind of these pieces that we know are really important around meeting all the diverse families that come into Virginia schools and giving them the kind of responsive culturally responsive experience that helps them learn and grow and all of these things are important and the reasons they are on this list is because when we think about how to make

[00:29:13] a high quality experience for a child or if you think about the young children in your own lives who have been in classrooms you have a sense that there isn't one thing that makes a early childhood experience high quality there's a kind of a complicated combination of things that matter for making something really effective for children so that is why there are these long lists and obviously if you brought in a lot of early educators and other teachers to talk about what's important the list could get even longer and broader and people would be right because

[00:29:46] high quality can be complicated to to link to one or two specific things but where the challenges arise is that we have developed a system where there are so many things that sometimes get included as quality that is hard to get traction and in particular we have kind of these different sectors in early childhood and for each one we kind of operationalize what we mean by high quality a little bit differently and so sometimes in child care we're really focusing on meeting licensing requirements and the long list of kind of things that would make sure that a

[00:30:24] place is ensuring a safe and healthy environment to leave a child and then we look at how we think about head start and there are long federal guidelines around what quality how to operationalize quality there and again in a vpi classroom it would look a little bit different. And so this creates kind of a complexity around all the different ways we might think about quality. And when we kind of come together as a state and think about, okay, but how do we increase quality across all these systems? There is such a complexity across these many things that could be thought about that it creates difficulty

[00:31:02] to move forward. So on the next slide, I wanted to share that there has been a bunch of research happening over the past about five-ish years looking at different states' efforts to think about quality, define quality, think about how it gets measured statewide. And the key sort of finding from that research is we need to simplify that complex lengthy list of things and try to orient ourselves towards fewer things that are the most relevant and why is that important one

[00:31:41] it's just incredibly complicated to think about all of the long list of things that i put on that list to measure them correctly is costly to have people focus on all of them at the same time is hard and what the research tells us is that some of those things you could make quite a bit of progress on them and you still wouldn't expect to see any changes for young children's learning.

[00:32:06] So there's this need to focus on the things that we know from the research are the ones that are likely to really have a payoff and to really change the experience as young children have. And that sort of goes back to the ones that Amanda listed of all these kind of states and all the different things they've measured when people have done studies to say, okay, okay, which of those things actually correspond to how young children are learning in those classrooms? Those come down to what are those interactions

about and how are we supporting teachers to ensure they can do those kind of engaging, interesting interactions with young

[00:32:42] children so that kids get a lot out of their programs. So one piece is kind of focusing on the things we know matter from the research. The other thing is that we know that teachers are kind the drivers of what young children learn in these programs so when we think about how to improve quality we have to be thinking about things that teachers can actually move or the teachers have control over they can understand they can think about and then they think okay actionably what can i do in my classroom to move forward on this so certain things you can build a quality improvement system focused on ratios or group sizes but i as a teacher don't have a lot of

[00:33:20] ability to change those things in my own classroom I have the group of children who are in front of me but what I can change are the interactions assuming I get the support or I can implement different curricula assuming I get the support and resources to learn how to do that well so focusing a quality improvement system around things that teachers feel are important and that research show are important as far as measuring leading to changes in children's development across a variety of domains. So, you know, including their social, emotional well-being, etc., is kind of where the kind of advice is going for how states can really move forward.

[00:33:59] And what I'll talk about on the next slide is an example of a state context where that is the approach they have taken and sort of my team at UVA has been tracking over time what has happened to quality. So the figure that you're looking at is looking at the quality of teacher-child interactions as measured by the class, a tool that's widely used to capture those teacher-child interactions across every child care program, Head Start, and pre-K program operating in Louisiana over a four-year period. And we got really interested in studying what Louisiana was

[00:34:38] doing um for kind of two reasons one was similar to how um virginia's moving now there it was this focus on bringing child care head start and pre-k into a single system thinking about one definition of quality and really trying to push that forward um and and this kind of focus on like i said the pieces of quality that we think both can be changed that teachers have control over and that will matter for kids. And so when you look at this, you can sort of start on the left, which was the first year that they collected the statewide data and collected quality information in every single

[00:35:15] classroom. And you can see that there were these very large disparities. These light blue ball at the very bottom is the average class score in their publicly funded child care centers. Head Start is a little bit higher than that in the middle. And then you see that in the pre-K classrooms which were the ones serving the four-year-olds the quality was just substantially higher than in the programs that were serving kind of the majority of the youngest children who are getting access to publicly funded early childhood programs and so what happened there was a real focus on teacher-child interactions and not just as a tool to measure but also as a support around

[00:35:52] kind of professional development resources a whole bunch of different targeted investments to try to give teachers coaching and the resources they needed to move on these teacher-child interactions and what you can see sort of looking across time is that in all the different types of programs in the state in child care head start and pre-k there was sort of steady improvement over this period all of them were getting better on these interactions but the rate of improvement was particularly pronounced for the child care programs in part because it was really new to

[00:36:28] them to be thinking about um this definition of quality so much of how quality was measured before then was around just the licensing requirements which are important but in some ways a floor for just ensuring basic safety rather than focusing on the kind of interaction kids need to learn so this shift towards measuring quality providing supports around quality led to this um sort of sharp increase for them so that by the last year for which we have data you can see the system is now one in which the kind of quality a child is likely to receive is much more comparable

[00:37:03] across the different sectors and across the board higher. So, next slide, please. So I think both kind of from reading what other states have done and from my work in that particular state, there are some kind of clear lessons to how we drive system-wide improvement and how we can move towards a higher quality program for all children.

[00:37:27] One is you need a clear definition of what you mean by quality. And it doesn't need to be one thing, but it needs to be a clear thing that people can wrap their head around and understand. So we want something that obviously makes sense to policymakers and makes sense to researchers who are studying how you measure these teacher-child interactions.

[00:37:50] But we also want something that makes sense to teachers and to people who are with young children all the time. so something that just has the kind of face validity to say yeah okay i see what you're measuring i see why that's important that makes sense with my own experiences in the classroom and is something that i as a teacher feel i can control and have sort of agency over and then once you kind of create clear definitions of what you mean by quality there needs to be kind of a commitment to regularly measuring that quality and that's important to track our progress to be able to have you know a figure like we had to see okay has child care really improved are we narrowing

[00:38:28] those gaps and how are we capturing that data um and also to have very localized data back to programs back to teachers to see where are teachers struggling where do they need additional support so it's not just measuring for the sake of measuring but it's measuring for the sake of understanding where we need to provide greater support or give more resources um the third point um you know i put here is that that you know defining and measuring quality is obviously only one piece of how you drive quality improvement there is the resources necessary to help teachers get there so you can't just define and measure but you also need to support and that could be

[00:39:07] professional development that could be coaching we spend a lot of time talking about in child care how it also means reducing turnover and thinking about the compensation of teachers but pushing those types of reforms without linking them to some clear metric for how we were going to track progress is also a missed opportunity so it's this combination of a clear definition of actionable quality and a set of supports to make it happen and then the last point is a focus on equity and we know that kind of both at a system level how we think about the pre-k programs versus the the childcare programs all over this country has been quite different.

[00:39:45] So reducing the differences across different kinds of programs. We know that the experiences that four-year-olds are getting are quite different than what we have for two-year-olds and three-year-olds. So kind of equalizing for different ages of children and then thinking about the experiences and how they vary by race, by income and ensuring we're moving towards a more equitable system there as well is critical.

[00:40:08] So those are kind of the lessons on how we might think about state-level system building. And then the last thing I wanted to show you is just sort of where we are already in Virginia in some of this work.

[00:40:26] So obviously, measuring teacher-child interactions is not new in Virginia, and it's something that lots of teachers and centers and programs are familiar with. My team recently did a survey of early educators in Virginia. We surveyed about around 2,500 early educators across child care centers, pre-K programs, Head Starts, and family child care homes.

[00:40:49] A lot of that was about learning how things are going with COVID, what they need supports with, and things like that. But we also asked them questions about quality and how they're thinking about quality. And what I wanted to highlight is that already across all of these sectors around centers, schools, Head Starts, family child care homes. There is kind of a high level of existing buy-in for this focus on teacher-child interaction. So those first set of bars are questions that asked teachers how much they agree that ensuring high quality teacher-child interactions is a priority at their site. And again, this is kind of at the height of COVID. So there are many priorities in

[00:41:28] their site, but still nearly all teachers, the vast majority, about 90% across all sectors, did feel like those interactions are already the priority in their site. Then we asked teachers how well they themselves understand what the class is measuring and doing as a way to capture quality and measure.

[00:41:47] And you can see a little bit lower, but still across all the different programs, more than three quarters of the teachers are reporting high levels of understanding of the class and what it measures. And then the last set of bars there, again, for each of the teachers, we asked them, what What about focusing on this when you also have all the demands of COVID and other things going on in your program?

[00:42:11] Is focusing on the class still useful in this context? And you could see that, again, most, the vast majority, at least 70% across all programs and up to about 85% in some programs are agreeing that even in this very challenging time where teachers are juggling so much, this focus on interactions is something they are finding useful as they move forward.

[00:42:31] So kind of thinking through where we are in that process that I outlined, it seems like we already are sort of talking about a measure of quality that not only has Amanda sort of highlighted the science around, but there is already a sense among teachers that they understand it and they find it useful and that they see it as a priority for themselves and their programs.

[00:42:49] And I will stop there. Thanks, Daphna. So I'm going to switch over to talking about supporting children's growth over time. And I think, you know, in what kind of we've talked about up to this point, we've consistently said measure things that link to child outcomes.

[00:43:14] And in Virginia, there is a real opportunity here that we can actually connect those, connect that measurement, the measurement of what are the proximal processes that are happening in classrooms, such as the quality of teacher-child interactions and the use of a curriculum, among other things that are happening in the classroom.

[00:43:34] And we can actually see how that then links to progress over time and our children growing and our children learning. And we can do that at different levels. But again, if we are using data to support improvement, we have a real opportunity in Virginia that I think is fairly unique.

[00:43:51] So in the next slide, the Virginia Kindergarten Readiness Program, which right now we are using in all kindergarten classrooms It provides a system to help us understand readiness skills, and it provides tools to support early learning.

[00:44:11] So, and the Virginia Kindergarten Readiness Program is a set of coordinated assessments really importantly as kind of Daphna mentioned around kind of measuring quality teacher child interactions. children's skills is not new in Virginia. PALS has been measuring children's literacy for many 20 plus years. So, and what we, VKRP is relatively new. We started working on this in 2015, but it builds off of PALS and adds assessments of children's early math skills,

[00:44:49] self-regulation skills and their social skills to provide teachers with the more comprehensive pictures of student skills up to this point in the beginning um the fall and spring beginning and end of year of kindergarten and now we'll have we have the capacity and opportunity to do that at the beginning and the end of preschool so we have this opportunity now to actually look at growth from the beginning of preschool through the end of kindergarten on a set of skills that balance children's academic skills and their social emotional skills which I think is really

[00:45:25] a nice kind of link to them thinking about that measuring of quality. Importantly, VKRP is also a reporting system. So within that system of assessments, we've built in reports that provide data and information about children's readiness skills back at different levels. So we provide a report back um at student levels for teachers and we also provide a family report for teachers to then use with families to talk about children's readiness skills and then they there are kind of user-friendly reports at the classroom school division and state levels again to really it's

[00:46:04] not just the data that we are collecting this data but like who can use this data and for what purposes and then vkrp is also a set of instructional resources again if we want information about children's readiness skills to support learning we have to provide the scaffolds to do that so even within the system we provide instructional resources that are linked to the reporting system that help teachers kind of understand these skills and like what and what they could be doing in their classrooms to support to provide practices that support those skills

[00:46:41] so next slide um in this way the the data and the information that we are gathering from the virginia kindergarten readiness program can benefit educators leaders and families at each level of the system so again for teachers providing and as part of vkrp we provide kind of training on like thinking about their data how to interpret their data how to use their data to support instruction to build upon students' strengths and support their growth. At the program and the division level,

[00:47:18] you know, these data aggregated up to that level allow divisions and schools to identify where more resources are needed and what kinds of professional development will be helpful for teachers. When we first started implementing BKRP, a lot of school division leaders really focused their attention for example on supporting teachers to promote children's social emotional skills and actually doing some alignment between what was happening in their preschool classrooms and their kindergarten classrooms and that was because there was more attention brought

[00:47:55] to actually thinking about children's social emotional skills because before that there just wasn't a measure of it and then at the state level again in all these areas we should be advancing equity because we should be looking at this data to see where children are and we should be supporting children where they are to meet their needs and this is kind of just-in-time data at each point in which we can use

that data at the immediate level to support individual children and schools and families and even at the state level really thinking about where should we be there are limited resources and where should we be focusing our resources to provide more

[00:48:34] resources so that we can increase the availability of high quality early childhood education for examples to children who are coming from communities where they are living within low incomes or children who are coming from communities who are minoritized marginalized what are we doing and where are we sending our resources to provide more high quality opportunities so in summary I think Virginia is well prepared to support and measure children's growth over time here we will

[00:49:09] have a measure of classroom experiences that focus on what is most linked to child outcomes so being able to measure the quality of adult child interactions being able to measure the use of curriculum being very inclusive about publicly funded birth to five settings including infants toddlers preschoolers as we've talked about and across all the different settings vpi early childhood special ed head start early head start title one center-based care and family day homes

[00:49:45] so just the field and the scope of like who we are working on really does advance equity and then i think um the opportunity here is really being able to link children's experience to their school readiness outcomes. Having all of this data through kind of the Link v5 data portal, which Anita McGinty has been leading the development of, and these VKRP assessments, and PALS, which is already in use, really just provides an opportunity to kind of examine what we're doing and whether it's working over time and in a pretty unique way. I think that might be our

[00:50:23] last slide. Excellent. Thank you. So we wanted to make sure we held some time, and I think, Emily, we have it till just about 11 o'clock if you have any questions either about how quality is measured across these settings how states are tackling when they're facing requirements similar to what we are facing measurement and improvement how it all fits together in terms of being able to thoughtfully

[00:50:59] measure growth over time particularly among our youngest learners again we've got she didn't speak we've got dr mcginty who supports our pals work i know we've come in front of this group before talking about some of the literacy setbacks this year um as well as dr whitaker who thinks a lot about the math aspects of early childhood so we've got a a an all-star panel and just want to see if there's any questions uh from from the board now yeah are there any questions from board

[00:51:26] members uh mr swan yes uh good morning um awesome presentation um so my question is who will evaluate the teacher-child interactions in order to determine the quality. Sure, well let's talk, we'll talk a little bit tomorrow about the kind of a potential approach for Virginia. It might be helpful either Amanda or Daphne to talk a little bit about class and how class is not only used

[00:52:03] in Virginia but across the country to as one way, Mr. Swan, of measuring teacher-child interactions. yeah i'm happy to start and then other folks can jump in so i think within kind of uh at least the field of developmental and early childhood education uh research you can measure the quality of adult child and teacher child interactions in a multitude of ways and i have done so using a variety of tools i think the class tool is unique in that um it is it comes

[00:52:37] from research it comes from kind of a base of adult child interactions and with a basis and kind of attachment and I think the thing that is probably most unique about it is its capacity to actually get people reliably to look at the quality of teacher-child interactions through the same lens so the ability to

kind of get people through a relatively quick training to actually see interactions in a similar way and actually, you know, provide a metric or a quantitative score

[00:53:12] in which two people could walk into a classroom and score the same way. Across these systems, people tend to measure in who does that measurement and who actually conducts that observation is different across systems. Whether it is someone, you know, for formative purposes, it is good if it is someone who actually knows the teachers well and can kind of interpret that data and provide feedback on like hey we saw you do this and this was great and then this other instance we had this interaction and i'm wondering how we might be able to change that to better

[00:53:48] support a child so i think um i think you know in that way kind of someone who is local and kind of known to the program and known to the teacher is a really useful observer and we also kind of like to keep a check on like whether or not that that observation is um uh kind of more versus less objective um less biased um versus more you know you can have an independent observer come in and look at the classroom and see if they're kind of seeing things the same way so that varies and i think that jenna will talk about that tomorrow i will just say in terms of kind of um thinking and

[00:54:27] And there are other tools to measure the quality of teacher-child interactions or adult-child interactions. And I think that's important to think about. They are often complicated and difficult for people, for folks to get reliable on. I say that having kind of thrown away a semester's worth of data because I have not been able to get people to see things the same way in a video or a classroom based upon a particular measure.

[00:54:53] - Thank you so much. - Yeah, thank you. Dr. Robertson. - Yes, I'll echo Anthony's comments about how awesome it was. Indeed, we have all-star presenters here who have established the track record across the Commonwealth for so long.

[00:55:10] And thank you for your presentation today. I just wanna make this a shout out to UVA colleagues and to also thank you for your service and support of the UVA K-12 Advisory Council, which is comprised of 108 school superintendents who benefit directly from your service.

[00:55:31] You were also integral in the production of the Early Literacy Summit last October and the Early Childhood Summit. Prior to that, Jenna has a keen way of roping in top quality talent each time.

[00:55:47] I'm sorry I won't be at the meeting tomorrow, but very supportive of the presentations that are being made tomorrow. This is more than anything, it was just a shout out and a thank you. - Okay, thank you, Dr. Robertson. You guys can respond if you want to, but it's not sure that one required a response other than thanks.

[00:56:09] Anybody else? Dr. Wilson and then Ms. Halton. - Good morning, everyone. Thank you all for your time and for the presentation. Amanda, as you were responding to Mr. Swan's question about class, I'm curious, and maybe this comes at a different time, perhaps tomorrow, but thinking about those programs which are in family day settings family home settings in terms of you know this idea of who evaluates quality if you're a want you know a singleton so to speak that becomes more difficult and then how do you create systems

[00:56:46] perhaps among the single sites in or so i i suspect that that's part of the conversation or part of a model that either exists or could exist yeah and i'll let jenna talk more about that or just you know uh confirm that you'll talk more about that tomorrow but i do think like that the question about class and

family day homes is a good one because most of our a lot of our research and a lot of the things that have happened at scales have happened in kind of classroom based settings um more and more we are moving into the family day home setting so there is there

[00:57:21] you know people have thought about that and there is a way to kind of be able to do that but you're exactly right sitting like at a singleton in a family day home you're not you're not necessarily although many family day homes do create kind of communities like localities in a geographic area with family day homes so that there is kind of a built-in community but you want to make sure because there is that increased risk for isolation so who should that observer be and it and it is important it is critically important that you trust who that observer is in order for that feedback

[00:57:57] to be useful to you. Ms. Halton? So thank you. Echoing all the the compliments, we are really blessed here in Virginia to have national superstars working in this area and it's fun to watch you all help us make Virginia a national leader. So my questions are around, so I really appreciated the conversation about widespread acceptance of class. I am thinking I'm understanding from your responses to the last couple of questions that

[00:58:31] the widespread acceptance of class doesn't necessarily reflect all sectors yet that it's more the class that's more well known and and therefore well accepted in the classroom setting that you can comment on that as i lead into my next question which is uh you said that pals and vkrp are are widespread i assume again that that's just in the classroom settings and is it now all classroom settings um at some point um there was northern virginia jurisdiction or two that were

[00:59:05] doing something different have we have we gotten beyond that and then um and then um similar to the survey answers you survey you showed us about class acceptance i know pals has long been widely well accepted um in the classroom teacher context how about vkrp reception is that now as widely used and is widely accepted among the classroom teachers as um as pals has always been

[00:59:40] or long been yeah um daphna on the first question i didn't know if you wanted to talk through because you had that um last slide with the that had actually that the family day homes and kind of center-based programs that hadn't been had that as long of a history of class were actually kind of most uh they were very interested and had really high acceptance rates yeah so let me just say that and then you can answer the more vkrp and pals uh expansion ones but um where where that survey data came from is from our preschool development grant communities in virginia which

[01:00:17] is a growing portion of communities now all over Virginia. And so in those communities, family childcare homes are being included in class and it is a newer experience for them sort of historically as far as how familiar they would be with that compared to a VPI classroom as far as how often that's happened.

[01:00:37] And like Amanda said, of those communities, we have heard really positive things from the family childcare homes about it. And what I showed you were kind of the survey responses to clear items, but there's also the written responses. And I think the family childcare home teachers liked it a lot because of some of the isolation that people raised about this sector and working alone and working by yourself and wanting to sort of get the feedback and the reaction.

[01:01:05] So I think the experience of being observed and having someone use that tool and then give you feedback was very useful. had them say a lot of like when are they coming back when can i do more of

this so i think particularly in that sector um that's what we heard and that's really similar to the experiences in in louisiana too where i think it's like the absence of prior kind of coaching and these types of formative feedback i think makes people really receptive to this kind of experience and on the um

[01:01:38] on the vkrp uh front i would say that you know there's good acceptance in kind of kindergarten classrooms across divisions right now because that is where we are statewide and I will also say like we were just statewide for the first time in 2019 so all of the divisions didn't even have a full year of VKRP before COVID hit and school shut down so there wasn't even a spring assessment but we actually do have good connections and I think that that will help as we think about VKRP

[01:02:12] moving into the preschool space so similar to the way that we've enrolled out vkrp in kindergarten we started the rollout of vkrp and preschool already in a voluntary way so we have a set of preschool vpi divisions who have already voluntarily kind of elected um into vkrp and they could do that either kind of full scale also acknowledging that all these programs were already and have already been doing PALS. So in that way there's a history of kind of doing these assessments that I do think kind of builds kind of momentum and acceptance and wanting to kind of collect

[01:02:52] more information. So preschool programs this year could have elected to like bring on BKRP with the literacy, math, self-regulation, and social skills, but we also provided an option for programs to just take up the social emotional measures as well and that was a that was in part a response to covet and we had some programs who said we would really like that we'd really like that data so and i'll let jenna talk a little bit about the rollout but we definitely see the rollout of the krp happening kind of in kind of a stage where i you know a staging process um where it is voluntary

[01:03:28] at first and then we kind of move in across time so in the fall we'll move it into vpi program you know four-year state-funded classroom-based programs so vpi early childhood special education title one those programs and then provide an opportunity and an offering if other programs that have state funding would also like to pick it up and we have had private programs pick up the preschool vkrp so we have done those trainings already we've learned from them um and we know that that training is different because they don't they sometimes don't have the history

[01:04:06] of conducting assessments in the same way so the training looks a little bit different but we actually have um the opportunity we've seen good uptake across sectors jenna i don't know if you wanted to add anything to that the only piece i i would add ms olton is i think we're trying to be thoughtful about you know where we know it can be easily constructed as part of the day right and we've learned from vkrp with kindergartners that we think it's very possible in our school-based classrooms we've had some conversation with head start programs for instance if they were interested not required but as just a way of capturing what's happening

[01:04:46] with some of our most vulnerable um little learners knowing that oftentimes our head start serves our our our families who are in our most marginalized communities and then i think we we will, as Dr. Wilford noted, think about offering it. I want us to be cognizant for all of the points that Dr. Basak named, like not too much at once, right? And so kind of really sort of saying our first focus is on interactions. You know, I think we're talking about slowly providing accessible, affordable curriculum and support. And for those that are ready, this ability to then tie those

[01:05:25] things together what's happening in the classroom right how we're supporting educators to be very intentional about learning development and the extent to which that's really supporting children's

growth and learning um you know and maximizing it right kids are going to learn and grow wherever but maximizing it um is the kind of the three legs of the stool and i just think and you know with certain programs we're going to be want to be very very thoughtful and so that's why as you know as as uh daphne described but we've all these resources and have for the last few years going out to the preschool development grant communities and we've been surveying these educators and leaders you know every year right so that we can actually hear from them directly so are we going

[01:06:02] too fast too slow is this useful not useful and they get a um a gift card for participating so we can really we get to like definitely i can't remember like 80 of the teachers respond so we feel like we have a pretty good barometer on you know our pacing as we think about just so much right because there's some programs in our schools right i mean i think as mr swan can attest like these are things that are not unfamiliar to us assessment curriculum being observed when you think about our family day homes um these are all really new things for some and so really kind of be very thoughtful about we're creating a big tent but you know it doesn't mean we have to push

[01:06:39] everything at once to everybody okay uh miss davis dr main were you before me would you like to go first oh i'm sorry hands are up all over the place hard for me to keep track my comment was just a follow-on to you know what jenna noted and i too like everyone else uh acknowledged the incredible presentation that we had and thank the presenters for coming and sharing so so thoughtfully and i think the point that jenna made was certainly something that i think is going to be super

[01:07:18] important for the board to really wrestle with because of course even though we talk about publicly funded that these are programs with public funding the reality is that the public funding that they have is incredibly disparate right people are getting subsidy assistance to provide support which we know doesn't necessarily cover the full cost of care right so as we think about measuring or desiring having expectations making certain that the resources that are

[01:07:51] necessary to really help move people along is going to be essential for us there's nothing like having a standard set and not having the resources to get there and wanting to be there and this is such an important opportunity and so i really appreciate the mindset and the perspective that the department is deploying as it's thinking about bringing along other providers to be a part of making things better for all children so just wanted to add that to the mix thank you pam

[01:08:27] thank you president gecker and to piggyback off of dr man this is a boots on the ground perspective the um the class evaluation system is in operation here in the school that i'm in that right now and it all of the tenants of the class system extend well beyond the pre-k environment to create a positive environment across the school pre-k through five so i am i'm a big fan of of the class evaluation system and jenna and the ladies from uva thank you very much i'm a big fan of

[01:09:03] everything you're doing but moving forward and today might not be the time to have this discussion but dr mann brought up the disparities in funding i i see a huge need for us to to maybe have a conversation in the future about facilities and and where are we going to put all of these pre-k children that we're inviting into the schools i would love to have every three and four year old in my building and i would love to provide them with these services but other schools in southwest

[01:09:38] virginia and i'm sure other locations are physically limited by size and facilities too so if we could maybe think about that absolutely i mean one sort of you know it's great to hear in you know an elementary school leader talk about the class i mean we've i've found you know there's a lot of hand-

wringing about um you know how do we support our principals to understand what should be happening and she's got her manual right there is you know to understand what should be happening in those classrooms right i mean it should look very different in classrooms even if they both

[01:10:16] happen to be right 10 feet by by 12 feet square and one of the most efficient ways to help prepare elementary school principals is to go through what she's gone through and to kind of understand and to bring to bring that lens you raise a really important piece about access and and and um again i won't won't have easy answers tomorrow but i think you're going to hear me continue to come back to you thinking about this trade-off between quality and access as both you and dr mann have noted and we have to be thinking broadly again kind of across this array of settings to be able to serve more kids you know recognizing that not all of these settings get the same resources and

[01:10:53] thinking about that kind of you know where do we put the kids how do we support those educators how do we support those leaders those are really important questions so I don't have I don't have immediate answers on that but that is on the on the to-do list in terms of as we think about you know, it will fundamentally will continue to come back to you. It is going to be a combination of increasing access and strengthening quality that are the two core things that will help us as a board, you know, ensure that more kids have the opportunity to come to kindergarten ready.

[01:11:26] Dr. Duran. Thank you again, Jenna. It's always good to hear your presentations and your excitement and what you bring to us, the vision for what we can do moving forward. What I'm always going to take every opportunity to bring up is thinking about how we're going to implement and really support the professional learning that's needed, the time that's needed.

[01:11:51] It can't be one of those one-time, as we say sometimes, drive-by professional learning. We're going to really do what I believe you want us to do in your vision to have that consistency across the Commonwealth, regardless of even whether it's public or private, right, or even home. So can you just talk a little bit more about what your vision is around the professional learning that's needed, the resources that are needed, the commitment that we'll need to make as VDOE, as a board, to making sure this is all implemented? Because at the end of the day, many of us who work in the field, we understand it's about how you can get it done, and it's about

[01:12:28] changing mindset and changing the understanding and building the capacity of everyone who wants to do better by her students, but sometimes you don't know what you don't know. And how do we get that consistency is, I think, a challenge or thinking big term, like you always like us to think big terms across the Commonwealth. When you do that, it's very difficult to build capacity without having the resources. Can you just share a little bit about what your thoughts are on that and what you think we need to do more of? Yeah, and I'll be very brief. And I promise you, Dr.

[01:13:00] Duran, I'll bring more of this tomorrow when I talk about the practice year for the measurement and improvement system here on the ground in the commonwealth of about half the state i think the key reason we wanted to have these national experts speak about how we're structuring the system is i think that is an important first step like if you try to measure 15 things well at scale like you will fail right and and you will sort of not be able to do it it will be extremely costly and onerous and it will be very hard for kind of the whole system and remember i talk with us about we think it's ballpark about 6 000 sites and 10 000 publicly funded classrooms right kind

[01:13:37] of across the state and so you know the the one of the things that will ultimately enable us to implement successfully is our kind of you know work to say we know a lot of these things are are good right and and and that whole list that that presented to us but in terms of those that right now with this group matter most we're going to focus in on interactions and curriculum right and And then we can look really specifically at what the costs are, what the time required.

[01:14:06] That's often kind of a hidden cost, right? And then what it will take to scale. And we are making a lot of these dollars. We are going to flow out to communities to kind of build that capacity locally. As we noted, if a teacher turns over, right, two or three times a year, like we have to recognize that we have to put in place at the leader level and the instructional coach level and at the community level a set of individuals who can carry that information forward and are prepared to support you know our classrooms if that turnover occurs so we we have been really intentional about it i'll walk us through some of that tomorrow but that's partly why you'll sort

[01:14:44] of see we have a narrower focus on quality not because we don't think that quality is you know includes all of those things but because in order to be able to successful and to move um kind of to move kids and to help our pro all of our educators particularly our family day home and our child care educators be supported to improve like we can't bite off more than we think we can support but that's a little sneak preview for more to come tomorrow dr duran thank you very much and again as always when you come to talk to us that's always going to be a question of mine so you just i think no no no we've all got to be committed to doing is investing the right resources to

[01:15:20] to change our system requires building capacity investing in people and obviously having access is important but the quality then of what children are being able to access is in my mind even more important thank you anybody else i don't see anybody so i'd like to thank the panel participants uh it's always good to have world-class people with the board uh you know i can tell you we can use it as we move forward in this process, having the best advice from the best people is, you know,

[01:15:58] critically important to where we're going. You know, a lot of this dovetails in my mind with what we're going to be doing this afternoon, which is the linkage between evaluation and professional development, you know, how we can improve the delivery of the product. And, you know, I'm glad to have had this preview. Honestly, I would like to have some time, you know, some more time with the panel to talk about that linkage. I think that's what Dr. Duran was getting to and how we end up implementing. I think what you're doing here has got a lot of, I guess what we're doing

[01:16:30] here has got a lot of spillover into the K-12 system also. A lot of the concepts ought to carry forward. And it's not just about measuring, it's about measuring and then using those measurements to improve those areas of the system that need improvement and in our case and i think in your case you're focusing on the delivery system the teachers or the professionals who are in direct care of our kids so with that having been said uh the board will be adjourned until one o'clock when we come back for the retreat thanks to everybody who participated this morning

[01:17:08] thank you again great presentations all thank you thank you all



Coraggio Consulting · aguyonx.com